I knew it would not work, but got this vicarious pleasure of making Chandrasekhar lose his Rs 500.

'I will try,' I said.

Chandrasekhar and Sasi were elated.

Next time when a policeman came near our cell I called him and gave him the Rs 500. My co-accused had no idea that I had not asked him to get anything. The policeman, happy with the Rs 500 bonus for nothing, told me that we would be shifted to the Viyyur Central Jail in Thrissur the next morning, and sauntered off.

The two men waited through the night waiting for a tipple. I feigned sleep. Amidst the most harrowing experience of my life, here in a jail for the first time, in the company of menacing mice, I had a hearty laugh.

LESSONS IN VERNON

'I can weld like a dream, sir.'

In Vernon, my priority was to acquire the liquid propulsion technology as early as possible and get back to India. I had a mandate to head the team for five years. Members of the team had tenures varying from a year to three, and the plan was to send back a few who had finished their part of the job and bring in a few others, depending on the emerging needs and our men's specific area of expertise. On the whole, more than a hundred scientists and engineers worked on the project that lasted till 1980, and at any given point of time there were about fifty of them working at SEP.

While the primary job was to acquire the 'know-why', I realised this could be done only by winning the confidence of the French without being too intrusive. Joint development contracts have been drawn with mutual benefit, but there was always competition. Partners, in a way, practice cautious camaraderie.